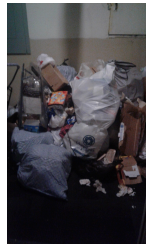


Case Study: The Addison Fire Tragedy – A Preventable Catastrophe through Negligence



Location: Addison on 4th Apartments, 308 4th Ave S, Seattle

Date of Incident: January 7, 2020

Prepared by: [Your Name/Organization]

Date Prepared: April 26, 2025

Executive Summary

The Addison Fire Tragedy on January 7, 2020, at the Addison on 4th Apartments exemplifies systemic negligence by the Seattle Department of Construction and Inspections (SDCI). A broken trash compactor, ignored despite multiple tenant complaints and Seattle Fire Department (SFD) warnings, led to hazardous conditions culminating in a high-rise fire. This case study details the timeline of events, SDCI's inaction, fraudulent inspection claims, and the resulting emergency, supported by official records and photographic evidence. It underscores the need for accountability to prevent future disasters.

Situation Overview: A Brewing Crisis Ignored

In Winter 2019, the Addison on 4th Apartments faced escalating health and safety violations starting around Thanksgiving (late November 2019). Official records from the Seattle Services Portal confirm:

- **Broken Trash Compactor:** Resulted in a trash chute backed up to the 6th floor, causing garbage to overflow into hallways and stairwells.^[^1]

- **Unsanitary Conditions:** Rotting food, flies, rats, roaches, human feces, and drug paraphernalia littered common areas.[^2]
- **Fire Hazards:** Blocked stairwells impeded emergency egress, with trash accumulation in all four stairways.[^3]

Despite persistent tenant complaints and SFD warnings, SDCI failed to enforce compliance, allowing these conditions to persist until the trash chute ignited on January 7, 2020, triggering a Code Red emergency response by 25 SFD units.[^4]

Background: Initial Warnings and SDCI's Response

The crisis was first documented on **November 9, 2019**, when the SFD filed a complaint noting "unsafe/unsanitary conditions in common areas" such as feces, needles, and garbage, urging SDCI to act.[^5]

- **December 6, 2019:** SDCI Inspector Stephen Rudolph confirmed violations, including:
 - Trash stored in stairwells and on the lower rooftop.
 - Broken window glazing in the corridor elevator lobby.
 - A broken trash compactor causing the chute to back up to the 6th floor.[^6]
- **December 16, 2019:** SDCI issued a Notice of Violation (NOV) with a compliance deadline of January 13, 2020—too late to prevent the fire.[^7]

Tenants amplified these concerns through repeated complaints, but SDCI's response remained inadequate.

Timeline of Complaints and SDCI Failures

The following timeline, sourced from Seattle Services Portal records, highlights SDCI's pattern of neglect and premature complaint closures:

1. **December 26, 2019 – Complaint #1 (011787-19CP)**
 - **Issue:** "3 weeks of backed-up trash chutes," with garbage attracting flies and rats. [^8]
 - **SDCI Action:** Assigned to Stephen Rudolph; closed as "ADMIN CLOSED" on January 6, 2020, without resolution.[^9]
2. **December 30, 2019 – Complaint #2 (011867-19CP)**
 - **Issue:** "Trash uncollected for over 3 weeks, garbage chutes backed up, no resolution plan."[^10]
 - **SDCI Action:** Inspected by Darren Wilson on January 30, 2020 (post-fire), marked "No Violation Observed," despite earlier closures by Rudolph.[^11]
3. **January 2, 2020 – Complaints #3 and #4 (000128-20CP, 000129-20CP)**
 - **Issue:** "Garbage chute broken for 3 weeks, unsanitary conditions, rat concerns."[^12]
 - **SDCI Action:** Both closed by Rudolph as "ADMIN CLOSED" on January 6, 2020.[^13]
4. **January 3, 2020 – Complaint #5 (000141-20CP)**
 - **Issue:** Persistent trash chute issues, bedbugs, malfunctioning heat, and security lapses.[^14]
 - **SDCI Action:** Closed by Rudolph on January 9, 2020, with a false note about a fire on January 31, 2020 (no fire occurred then).[^15]

5. **January 6, 2020 – Complaint (000239-20CP)**

- **Issue:** "Garbage piles in hallways, broken chute, human feces, fire alarms nightly."^[^16]
- **SDCI Action:** Closed as "ADMIN CLOSED" on January 8, 2020, post-fire.^[^17]

6. **January 7, 2020 – The Fire (000238-20CP)**

- **Event:** Trash chute ignited, confirmed by tenant photos of blocked stairwells.^[^18]
- **SDCI Claim:** Rudolph claimed he was on-site but "wasn't allowed access," despite prior closures.^[^19]
- **SFD Response:** 25 units dispatched to extinguish the fire and clear the chute.^[^20]

7. **January 8, 2020 – Follow-Up (000279-20CP)**

- **Issue:** Confirmation of the fire and SFD's intervention.^[^21]
- **SDCI Action:** Closed by Rudolph as "ADMIN CLOSED."^[^22]

Visual Evidence: Undeniable Hazards

Tenant-provided photos offer irrefutable proof of the dangerous conditions at Addison on 4th:

- **Image 0:** Stephen Rudolph's notes (12/6/2019) confirming trash chute backup to the 6th floor.^[^23]
- **Image 1:** Trash overflowing in hallways, with flies and rodents visible.^[^24]
- **Image 3:** Stairwells blocked by garbage bags, annotated with "TRASH ACCUMULATED ALL 4 STAIRWAYS- UNSAFE FIRE EXIT."^[^25]
- **Image 4:** Human feces and drug paraphernalia in common areas.^[^26]
- **Image 5:** Rudolph's notes confirming violations, yet complaints were closed.^[^27]

The Cover-Up: Fraudulent Inspection Claims

SDCI's actions suggest a deliberate attempt to mask negligence:

- **Premature Closures:** Rudolph closed complaints on January 6, 2020, without resolving documented issues, hours before the fire.^[^28]
- **False Inspection Claim:** On January 7, 2020, Rudolph claimed he couldn't access the property, contradicting his prior closures.^[^29]
- **Backdated Excuse:** On January 31, 2020, Rudolph falsely noted a fire prevented inspection, though the actual fire occurred on January 7, 2020.^[^30]
- **Missing Records:** Annotations note "2016-2019 COMPLAINTS MISSING" and a "NOTICE OF VIOLATION... DISAPPEARED," suggesting data suppression.^[^31]

Key Findings

- **Ignored Warnings:** SDCI disregarded tenant and SFD complaints, closing them without action.
- **Direct Contribution:** Unaddressed trash buildup caused the fire, a preventable outcome of SDCI's inaction.
- **Falsified Reports:** Rudolph's post-fire claims appear fraudulent, aimed at covering up SDCI's failures.

- **Massive Response:** The SFD's 25-unit deployment underscores the severity of the crisis SDCI could have averted.

Recommendations

- **Investigate SDCI Practices:** Conduct an independent audit of SDCI's complaint handling and inspection processes.
- **Enhance Accountability:** Implement stricter oversight to ensure timely responses to tenant complaints.
- **Improve Record-Keeping:** Address missing records and ensure transparency in violation tracking.
- **Strengthen Enforcement:** Enforce housing codes proactively to prevent hazardous conditions from escalating.

Conclusion

The Addison Fire Tragedy was a preventable disaster rooted in systemic negligence by SDCI. By neglecting its duty to enforce housing codes, closing complaints without resolution, and potentially falsifying records, SDCI allowed a manageable issue to escalate into a life-threatening emergency. This case demands accountability to protect Seattle renters from a broken enforcement system that prioritizes administrative convenience over public safety.

Citations

- [^1]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 010696-19CP, Image 0, December 6, 2019.
- [^2]: Seattle Services Portal, Images 1, 4, 5.
- [^3]: Seattle Services Portal, Image 3, January 7, 2020.
- [^4]: Seattle Fire Department, Code Red response, January 7, 2020.
- [^5]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 010696-19CP, November 9, 2019.
- [^6]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 1049214-VI, December 6, 2019.
- [^7]: Seattle Services Portal, NOV issued December 16, 2019.
- [^8]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 011787-19CP, December 26, 2019.
- [^9]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 011787-19CP, closed January 6, 2020.
- [^10]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 011867-19CP, December 30, 2019.
- [^11]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 011867-19CP, inspected January 30, 2020.
- [^12]: Seattle Services Portal, Records 000128-20CP and 000129-20CP, January 2, 2020.
- [^13]: Seattle Services Portal, Records 000128-20CP and 000129-20CP, closed January 6, 2020.
- [^14]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000141-20CP, January 3, 2020.
- [^15]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000141-20CP, closed January 9, 2020.
- [^16]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000239-20CP, January 6, 2020.
- [^17]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000239-20CP, closed January 8, 2020.
- [^18]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000238-20CP, January 7, 2020.
- [^19]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000141-20CP, Rudolph's note, January 7, 2020.
- [^20]: Seattle Fire Department, Code Red response, January 7, 2020.
- [^21]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000279-20CP, January 8, 2020.
- [^22]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000279-20CP, closed January 8, 2020.

[^23]: Seattle Services Portal, Image 0, December 6, 2019.

[^24]: Seattle Services Portal, Image 1.

[^25]: Seattle Services Portal, Image 3, January 7, 2020.

[^26]: Seattle Services Portal, Image 4.

[^27]: Seattle Services Portal, Image 5.

[^28]: Seattle Services Portal, Records 011787-19CP, 000128-20CP, 000129-20CP, closed January 6, 2020.

[^29]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000141-20CP, Rudolph's note, January 7, 2020.

[^30]: Seattle Services Portal, Record 000141-20CP, Rudolph's note, January 31, 2020.

[^31]: Seattle Services Portal, Image 7, annotations on missing records.

Image Placeholders for Canva

- **Image 0:** Stephen Rudolph's inspection notes, December 6, 2019.
- **Image 1:** Trash overflowing in hallways, with flies and rodents.
- **Image 3:** Stairwells blocked by garbage, annotated with "UNSAFE FIRE EXIT."
- **Image 4:** Human feces and drug paraphernalia in common areas.
- **Image 5:** Rudolph's notes confirming violations.
- **Image 7:** Annotations noting "NOTICE OF VIOLATION... DISAPPEARED."

Instructions for Canva: Copy each section into a text box. Insert images at the corresponding placeholders under the "Visual Evidence" section or as needed. Adjust font sizes and styles (e.g., bold headings, bullet points) to enhance readability.